



NCL Bliss — Alaska Solo Group

July 11–18, 2026 · Kristie McClung Escoe, host

Ship: Norwegian Bliss · **Sailing from:** Pier 66, Seattle · **Cabin:** _____

A condensed Voyage Pack from [In the Wake](#) — the essentials in three pages. The full pack covers cabins, packing, budget, ship orientation, ports in depth, and first-cruise notes.

Day by day

#	Date	Port	Hours ashore	Tender	The one thing
1	Sat Jul 11	Seattle — embarkation	board 11:30 AM – 3:00 PM; depart 4 PM	—	All-aboard 2 PM. Kristie at Sea View Bar, Deck 17 for sailaway.
2	Sun Jul 12	Inside Passage (sea day)	—	—	Settling-in day. Teppanyaki 5:00 PM — group dinner.
3	Mon Jul 13	Sitka	10:00 AM – 6:00 PM	yes	Sitka National Historical Park totem trail (free, 30-min walk) or sea-otter boat tour (~\$210).
4	Tue Jul 14	Juneau + Dawes Glacier	Juneau 6:30 AM – 1:30 PM; Dawes ~3:00–7:00 PM scenic-cruising	no	Mendenhall via M&M Tours (\$79, 3 hrs). Cagney's 5:30 PM conflicts with glacier face — choose.
5	Wed Jul 15	Icy Strait Point	mid-morning – evening	yes	World's Largest ZipRider (\$199) or whale-watching. Le Bistro 5:45 PM — group dinner.
6	Thu Jul 16	Ketchikan / Ward Cove	6:00 AM – 1:15 PM	no, but Ward Cove + NCL shuttle (20–30 min to downtown)	Creek Street + Totem Heritage Center. Tight day; pick one focus.
7	Fri Jul 17	Victoria, BC	8:00 PM – 11:59 PM	no, Ogden Point + shuttle	Inner Harbour walk at night. Passport required.
8	Sat Jul 18	Seattle — debarkation	off by 10:00 AM	—	Port Valet if eligible (see page 2).

Three group specialty dinners are pre-booked with Kristie: Teppanyaki (Day 2), Cagney's (Day 4 — glacier conflict), Le Bistro (Day 5). The 3-meal NCL Specialty Dining Package covers all three if you're attending each.

Mandatory muster drill is the afternoon of Day 1 — partly app-based (watch safety video in the NCL app before sailaway) plus an in-person check-in at your assigned station.

Currency aboard: USD. **Sea days vs. port days:** 2 sea-day-style segments (Day 2 full sea day; Day 4 afternoon scenic-cruising). 5 days ashore.

Decide before you board. Run the [drink-calculator](#) on your real drinking pattern (Premium Beverage Package math is real for Alaska — port days don't lend themselves to drinking from breakfast), the [budget-calculator](#) for the total-fare picture, and the [tipping-calculator](#) for auto-grats + cash tips. Tina can confirm what's bundled in Free at Sea.

Verify your specific day order in the NCL app — the published sequence sometimes shifts between sailings.

Getting to the ship — and getting home

Arrival: Friday optional, Saturday required

Friday, July 10 — optional “Get Acquainted” dinner. Kristie hosts an 8:30 PM happy-hour gathering at **Currant Bistro** inside the **Sound Hotel Seattle Belltown** (2120 4th Ave). Casual; appetizers and drinks à la carte. Confirm attendance with Kristie if you want a seat saved.

Where to stay Friday night. Sound Hotel Belltown is convenient (you’re already there for dinner). Anywhere in Belltown, Downtown, or near Pike Place puts you within walking distance of Pier 66.

Saturday, July 11 — embarkation.

- **Terminal: Bell Street Cruise Terminal at Pier 66**, 2225 Alaskan Way, Seattle. *Different terminal from Pier 91 used by RCL/Princess/HAL.*
- **Sea-Tac (SEA) → Pier 66:** Uber/Lyft 30–40 min, \$40–60.
- **If driving:** Bell Street Pier garage directly across from the terminal, ~\$33/day, max vehicle height 6’6”, reservable in advance.
- **Early luggage drop-off: 8:00 AM** at the terminal.
- **Embark window:** 11:30 AM – 3:00 PM. **All-aboard 2:00 PM.** Ship departs ~4:00 PM.
- **Saturday morning options after bag drop:** Pike Place Market (quietest before 9 AM); Biscuit Bitch Belltown breakfast; waterfront walk; back to terminal by 2 PM.

Day 8 debark and the trip home

- **6:30 AM:** Bags must be in the hall the night before — NCL color-codes by tag.
- **7:00 – 9:30 AM:** Walk-off in waves. **Self-disembarkation** (carry all bags off) starts ~7:00 AM, fastest if you have a flight to catch.
- **10:00 AM (latest):** All passengers off.

Port Valet — use it. The Port of Seattle’s free service transfers your checked bag from the ship directly to your final-destination airline check-in. Walk off Bliss with only your carry-on; bag meets you in baggage claim at home. Available for most major airlines on most departure days; sign-up sheet distributed onboard mid-cruise (typically Day 4 or 5 — watch the *Freestyle Daily*). **The single most useful piece of post-cruise logistics in Seattle.**

Bag storage (if Port Valet didn’t fit your routing): Pier 66 Crew Center, **\$6/bag/day, pickup by 3 PM.**

Getting to SEA without an Uber — Pier 66 is the pack where this actually works. From Pier 66, walk 8 minutes to **Westlake Station** and catch the **Link light rail** directly to SEA: **\$3.50, ~40 minutes, no transfer.** The cheapest, most reliable airport route from any Seattle cruise pier. Trains run every 8 min.

Uber/Lyft from Pier 66 to SEA: \$40–60, 25–35 minutes.

Killing 4–6 hours before an evening flight. Pier 66 is downtown — most of central Seattle is walkable from the terminal:

- **Pike Place Market** — 10-min walk, uphill on the return.
- **Olympic Sculpture Park** — 5-min walk north along the waterfront. Free.
- **Seattle Aquarium** — 5-min walk south, \$40, ~90 min.
- **Space Needle + Chihuly Garden** — 15-min walk or 5-min Uber to Seattle Center; ~90 min combined visit.

Airport-arrival timing.

Flight	Leave Pier 66 by
Domestic, after 5 PM	2:00 PM (Link) or 2:30 PM (Uber)
International, after 7 PM	3:00 PM

SEA TSA lines run 30–60 min during Saturday afternoon cruise debark.

Areas of interest during the cruise

On the ship — Bliss spots worth knowing

- **Observation Lounge** (Deck 15 forward) — the day's best move. Heated, glass-roofed, panoramic; the first hour after sunrise has the best light. Quiet at 6 AM with coffee; busiest mid-morning during glacier viewing.
- **Sea View Bar** (Deck 17 aft) — Kristie's sailaway location and the de-facto group gathering spot. Open-air, panoramic; less crowded than the main pool deck.
- **Studio Lounge** (Deck 11) — solo-cabin perk. Hosted coffee hour most sea-day mornings; check the daily program. Even if you're not in a Studio, it's where solo cruisers cluster.
- **The Waterfront** (Deck 8) — partial outdoor promenade with bars and seating; the best non-Observation outdoor space for glacier afternoons. Wind-protected on the leeward side.
- **Wyland's whale mural** — the 270-foot painted humpback wraps the bow and starboard side of the hull. Best viewing: a Zodiac tour or shore excursion that puts you in the water alongside her. From the ship itself, you can see the tail and flukes from Deck 6–8 aft, starboard.
- **Garden Café** (Deck 16, buffet) — upper-deck windows look down on the pool deck. The breakfast view of Alaska coastline is the underrated meal of the week.
- **Manhattan Room** (Deck 7 aft) — main dining room with live music most evenings and a small dance floor. Most atmospheric of the included dining rooms.

Sea-day priorities (Day 2 — Sunday)

1. **Coffee in the Observation Lounge** at sunrise. Best 30 minutes of the week.
2. **Studio Lounge coffee hour** if you're in a Studio — most often Day 2 morning.
3. **Mandara Spa thermal-suite day pass** — sea-day intro rates appear. ~90 minutes is the right dose.
4. **Ocean Loops waterslide** — first hour after opening has zero line.
5. **Bridge or behind-the-scenes ship tour** if scheduled in the Cruise Planner.

Day 4 — the Dawes Glacier hours

The afternoon is the visual event of the week. Best deck spots:

- **Your own balcony** (warm coffee, your own pace) if you have one.
- **Observation Lounge** — heated and glass-roofed; the best of both worlds.
- **Sea View Bar** — open-air, panoramic; the cold-loving spot.
- **Deck 8 Waterfront** — open to the bow but windy.

Kristie's Cagney's 5:30 PM dinner sits in the middle of the glacier approach. Decide ahead.

Port-day picks (one each)

- **Sitka** — totem trail at Sitka National Historical Park (free, 30-min walk).
- **Juneau** — Mendenhall via M&M Tours (\$79, 3 hrs). Or morning whale watch if you can confirm the 7:30 AM pickup.
- **Icy Strait Point** — World's Largest ZipRider (\$199) or whale watching. Book the ZipRider early Day 1.
- **Ketchikan** — Creek Street + Totem Heritage Center. Skip the Ward Cove venue if you have time downtown.
- **Victoria** (8 PM – midnight) — Inner Harbour walk. The Parliament Buildings lit at night are the trip's quiet last image.

Where Kristie sets the rhythm

- **Day 1 sailaway** — Sea View Bar, Deck 17, 4:00 PM.
- **Day 1 group dinner** — venue TBD; ask Kristie or watch her communications.
- **Day 2 (sea day) Teppanyaki** — 5:00 PM group dinner; arrive 5–10 minutes early for group seating.
- **Day 4 Cagney's** — 5:30 PM group steak dinner during the glacier approach.
- **Day 5 (ISP) Le Bistro** — 5:45 PM; easiest of the three group nights to make on time.

Photo spots worth knowing

- **Sea View Bar Deck 17 sailaway** — Seattle skyline + Mount Rainier (clear days) behind the wake.
- **Sitka totem trail** — sunlight through old-growth; 9 AM has the best light.
- **Dawes Glacier face from the Observation Lounge** — the ice fills the windows.
- **Creek Street, Ketchikan** — boardwalk with salmon visible below in season.
- **Victoria Inner Harbour at night** — Parliament Buildings illuminated.

Need an at-home emergency handoff card? It's a separate one-page doc — ask Kristie or download from [In the Wake](#). The full Voyage Pack is the unabridged companion document. Soli Deo Gloria.